From the Dispatch Box: Unlocking Topics and Sentiments in Multilingual ParlaMint Corpora (Workshop)

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Background and overview

Parliaments are pivotal institutions in democracies, shaping policies that impact citizens by deliberating critical societal issues. The debates are commonly recorded as open-access digital proceedings enriched with metadata. These records are valuable for researchers exploring political, societal, historical, cultural or communicational dynamics. Improved access to data and advancing technologies expand interest in parliamentary studies (Lenardič / Fišer 2022).

This **half-day hands-on tutorial** will present the ParlaMint family of corpora, notable for its adherence to FAIR principles, comparable design for transnational and translingual research, extensive linguistic annotations, and rich metadata. The ParlaMint corpora (Erjavec et al. 2024) contain over a billion words from parliamentary sessions across 29 European countries and regions, spanning at least 2015–2022. Available in the original languages and machine-translated to English , the corpora feature metadata on speakers, parties and speeches, including names, gender, age, roles, party affiliation, power positions, political leanings, speech dates, sessions and terms. Previous workshops like *ParlaCLARIN* (Fišer et al. 2024) and *Digital Parliamentary Data in Action, or DiPaDA* (La Mela et al. 2022) as well as tutorials like *Put Them In to Get Them Out* (Fišer et al. 2023) and *Voices of the Parliament* (Fišer / Pahor de Maiti 2021) highlight the ongoing need for in-depth introductions to these data.

This tutorial will provide skills and methodological training to explore ParlaMint version 5.0 with an emphasis on two newly introduced variables – topic and sentiment information – offering deeper insights into parliamentary agenda-setting and discourse dynamics (Abercrombie / Batista-Navarro 2020). Under the ParlaCAP project , the ParlaMint corpora are annotated with topics following the Comparative Agendas Project (CAP) coding schema and sentiment information coded with the ParlaSent multilingual transformer language model (Mochtak et al. 2024).

Designed for researchers with no or little familiarity with corpus linguistic tools, in particular noSketchEngine, this tutorial will train participants to leverage extensive content, annotations and metadata via user-friendly concordancers, facilitating research on individual national parliaments, enabling transnational comparisons, and fostering cross-disciplinary collaboration.

Relevance to the Digital Humanities community

While parliamentary data are often accessible, most parliamentary corpora are project-specific, limiting reuse for diverse research questions within the heterogeneous DH community. ParlaMint addresses this by offering a large family of fully comparable corpora, annotated with a clear methodology across numerous metadata categories. It was designed as a sustainable initiative to ensure ongoing maintenance, upgrades and free long-term access to the data both via the CLARIN.SI repository download option and user-friendly tools like the CLARIN.SI noSketchEngine concordancer and the TEITOK service.

Instructors

Anna Kryvenko holds a PhD in linguistics and has over 15 years of experience teaching lexical semantics, corpus analysis and discourse studies at the university level. Her research interests include language corpus approaches to social studies and metaphor in political discourse. Currently she is working on her postdoc MSCA Seal of Excellence project “The Changing Discursive Semantics of EU representations: Identity, Populism, Propaganda” funded by ARIS (Slovenia). She is a

contributing partner for the ParlaMint-UA corpus and a participant of the ParlaCAP project.

Kristina Pahor de Maiti Tekavčič is a linguist utilizing discourse analysis, pragmatics, corpus linguistics and digital methods to explore the descriptive and constitutive nature of language. She focuses on methodological and discourse analytical approaches to figurative language use in various text genres. Currently, she is completing her PhD thesis on the argumentative power of metaphors in socially unacceptable discourse in digitally mediated communication. She also participates in the Horizon Europe ARENAS project, analyzing the use and responses to extremist narratives in the media and parliaments across Europe.

Target audience and expected number of participants

This tutorial targets DH and SSH scholars interested in using parliamentary corpora to study socio-cultural phenomena, focusing on metadata annotations for corpus-assisted discourse analysis rather than purely linguistic topics. No programming skills are required. To allow time for hands-on exercises and discussion, the group size should be limited to 15 participants.

Learning outcomes

Participants will gain basic skills for querying ParlaMint corpora, including simple search strings and advanced CQL queries. They will learn to analyze extracted results alongside speaker and text metadata, including sentiment and topic analysis under the ParlaCAP project. Additionally, they learn to frame and interpret the results for various Digital Humanities and Social Sciences research questions, such as comparing speeches and attitudes of ruling and opposition parties or exploring parliamentary protocol variations. The techniques taught are transferable to other corpora and concordancers. The showcases will use the ParlaMint-GB and Parlamint_xx_en corpora to ensure all participants can follow queries in English and discuss results, but they will be encouraged to use ParlaMint corpora in other languages for the hands-on activities.

Requirements for technical support

Conference organizers should provide an LCD projector with a HDMI output, WIFI and some power extension cords for the participants. Participants should bring their own laptops. Participants are also advised to create a free personal account at https://www.clarin.si/skelog prior to the beginning of the workshop.

Timeline

(3.5 hours total incl. 30 min break)

Part 1 – Introduction and demo session (1,5h):

15 min. - Introduction and overview of the ParlaMint and ParlaCAP projects
20 min. - Types of metadata and linguistic annotation in ParlaMint v. 5.0
20 min. - Showcase 1: gendered dimension of topic preferences
20 min. - Showcase 2: sentiment distribution for the concepts of Europe and Brexit
15 min. - Q&A
Break – 30 min

Part 2 – Hands-on session (1,5h):

20 min. - Showcase 3: populist rhetoric in parliament
10 min. - Q&A
45 min. - Hands-on work related to participants' research interests or replication of a use case
15 min. - Discussion of results, potential and user needs for the ParlaMint corpora

Acknowledgement

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